

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But that Predictor did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predictor.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,
either.

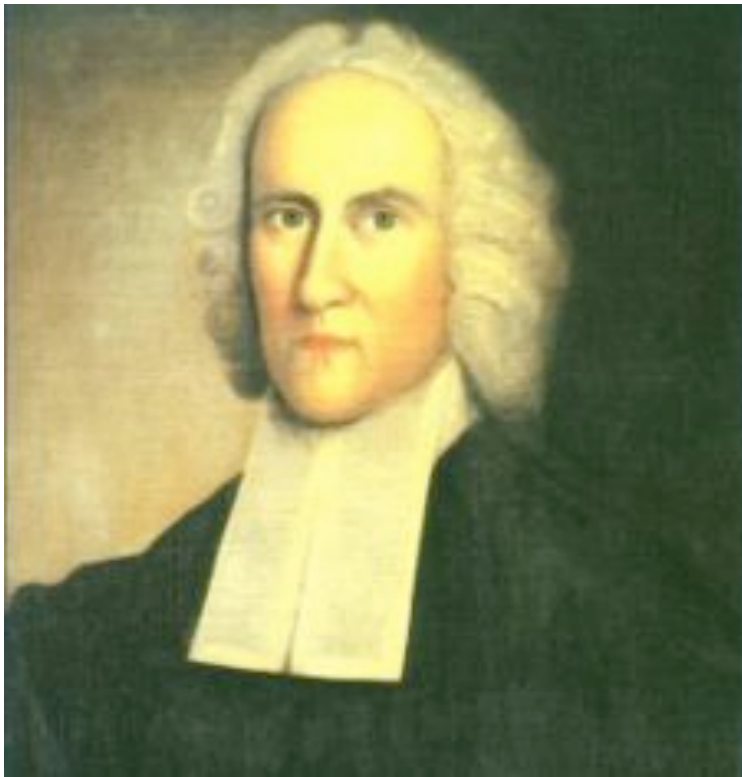
So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments — the story of Osmo, and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a thing as fate, then there is no free will.

One might wonder: can we come up with an argument which starts with the reality of fate — i.e., the reality of truths about the future — and uses this to show that free will is an illusion?

We can. The best way to see how this argument might work is to start with a challenge to free will which is closely related to the challenge posed by fate. This is the challenge posed by God's foreknowledge of our actions.

The argument we're going to talk about is due to Jonathan Edwards.

Edwards was an 18th century American philosopher, theologian and preacher, perhaps best known now for his sermon, "Sinners in the Hands of An Angry God."



Edwards lays out his argument in four numbered paragraphs, each of which corresponds to a premise in his argument.

The first is this one:

in other words:

1. We have no choice about
past facts.

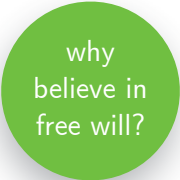
“1. I observed before, in explaining the nature of necessity, that in things which are past, their past existence is now necessary: having already made sure of existence, it is too late for any possibility of alteration in that respect ... ”



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
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three
ways out

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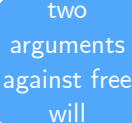
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serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

responding to Edwards' argument. But

for fatalsn.

first let's think about how Edwards'

argument might be related to an argument

We'll shortly consider some ways of

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

actions. Could they give an argument

there were truths about all our future

Suppose that someone did not believe in

similar to Edwards' argument?

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about

(5) Let's look at what happens if we



3 We have not at the fact that

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

then we have the choice about q.

2* In the past, there were truths about

God knows that in the future I will

5* We have not decided what the fact

1. We have no direct facts.

some action, then I will prefer that

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,



all of our activities.

perform a certain action (1,2)

will perform various actions.

that if it is true that I will perform

(3, 4, 5)

0 We have achieved what we

acaioid.

The fatalist argument

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to





parasitiforms.

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